OKLAHOMA

The Sooner State



The land that became Oklahoma was shaped by fire, drought, and an extraordinary gathering of peoples—and the cooking that emerged from it carries every one of those influences in its bones.

When the Five Civilized Tribes—the Cherokee, Choctaw, Chickasaw, Creek, and Seminole—were forcibly relocated to Indian Territory along the Trail of Tears in the 1830s, they carried with them a deep knowledge of corn. For these nations, corn was not simply a crop. It was ceremonial, communal, and central to survival. The Choctaw in particular had been grinding corn into meal and baking it over open fire long before European contact, producing early forms of flat cornbread that sustained entire communities through planting seasons, harvests, and hardship alike.

When African American settlers arrived—some as enslaved people brought by tribal members, and later as freedmen establishing their own communities after the Civil War—they brought with them the Southern cast iron skillet and a cornbread tradition refined over generations in the kitchens of the Deep South. Towns like Boley and Langston, two of Oklahoma's most celebrated all-Black townships, became centers of this cooking culture. Women in those communities knew that a well-seasoned cast iron skillet, heated until it smoked, was the secret to cornbread with a crackling, golden crust that no baking pan could ever replicate. The batter hitting that hot iron was a sound and a smell that meant home.

The Land Run of 1889 brought yet another wave of settlers pouring across the Oklahoma Territory border—homesteaders from Tennessee, Texas, Arkansas, and beyond, staking claims on the tallgrass prairie with little more than a wagon, a cook fire, and a cast iron skillet packed among their most essential possessions. For these families, cornbread was practical and economical, made from the meal they could mill themselves and baked over an open flame or in a wood stove. It fed field hands during wheat harvests, stretched meals through the lean years of the Dust Bowl in the 1930s, and sat alongside beans and salt pork on tables across the red dirt plains of Canadian, Caddo, and Grady counties.

What makes Oklahoma cornbread distinct is exactly that layered history—Native tradition, African American culinary mastery, and pioneer practicality all pressed together in a single iron pan. It is not sweet like its Northern counterpart. It is savory, sturdy, and deeply satisfying, with a crust that shatters at the touch and an interior that stays tender and warm long after it leaves the oven.

When you pour your batter into a smoking hot cast iron skillet today, you are participating in something that spans nearly two centuries of Oklahoma life. The sizzle you hear is the same sizzle that rang out in Choctaw cooking camps, in Boley kitchens, and on homestead stovetops across the prairie. This is the kind of bread that built a state—and once you taste it fresh from the skillet, golden-edged and steaming, you will understand completely why no one ever let the tradition go.

CAST-IRON SKILLET CORNBREAD

There is no sound quite like the sizzle of buttermilk batter hitting a blazing cast iron skillet, and no smell quite like the golden cornbread that Oklahoma kitchens have been pulling from the oven for generations—crisp-edged, tender-hearted, and worth every burn on your forearm.

Yield: One 9–10-inch cornbread

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INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup yellow cornmeal (preferably medium or stone-ground)
- ½ cup all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 large egg
- 1 cup buttermilk
- 2 Tbsp unsalted butter + 1–2 Tbsp bacon drippings or neutral oil (for skillet)

OKLAHOMA-STYLE OPTIONS

- ½ cup corn kernels (fresh, canned, or frozen, drained)
- 1 jalapeño, seeded and diced
- 2 Tbsp chopped scallions or chives
- ½ cup shredded cheddar cheese

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Preheat skillet & oven*: Place a 9- or 10-inch cast iron skillet in the oven and preheat to 425°F (220°C). Let the skillet heat for at least 10 minutes so it becomes sizzling hot.
2. *Mix dry ingredients*: In a mixing bowl, whisk together the cornmeal, flour, baking powder, baking soda, and salt.
3. *Mix wet ingredients*: In another bowl, beat the egg and stir in buttermilk.
4. *Combine batter*: Pour the wet into the dry, stirring just until moistened. If you are using add-ins (corn, jalapeño, cheese), fold them in now. The batter should be thick but pourable—not too runny.
5. *Add fat to skillet*: When your skillet is hot, carefully add the butter plus bacon drippings or oil, swirling to melt and coat the bottom. It should sizzle.
6. *Pour batter & bake*: Immediately pour the batter into the hot skillet (listen for the sizzle). Smooth the top gently. Bake in the oven for 20–25 minutes, or until the top is golden brown, the edges are crisp, and a toothpick inserted in the center comes out clean.
7. *Cool & serve*: Let the cornbread rest 5 minutes in the skillet. Then slice into wedges and serve warm (preferably right in the skillet) with butter, honey, or alongside chili, beans, greens, or stews.

NOTES & TIPS

- Balance flavors: Because this cornbread is less sweet, the contrast with savory mains is excellent. If you want a hint of sweetness, drizzle honey or sorghum syrup.
- Crispy edges: The secret to the crispy crust is a very hot, well-seasoned skillet plus enough fat (butter + drippings or oil).
- Don't overmix: Overworking the batter leads to tougher texture; stir just until the dry is absorbed.
- Alternate cooking surfaces: If you lack a cast iron skillet, you may use an oven-safe heavy pan or even a cake pan, but you'll lose some of the crust character.

